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2027 CYCLE

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CUET UG

Political Science

Democratic Upsurge and Coalition Politics

Official Syllabus · Politics in India Since Independence · Class 12 · CUET UG 2027 Cycle Notes

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Politics in India Since Independence)	Skills the questions test
The 1990s Transition & Mandal Issue	The 1990s transition — decline of Congress and rise of coalition politics; the Mandal Commission and Other Backward Classes (OBC) reservation.	Identifying the five major developments of the 1990s, the Kaka Kalelkar and B.P. Mandal Commissions, and the 1992 Indra Sawhney ruling.
Coalition Regimes (1989–2014)	National Front, United Front, NDA, and UPA coalitions — Prime Ministerial transitions and policy hallmarks.	Tracing the outside support dynamics (1989 NF, 1996 UF), Vajpayee's NDA tenures, the UPA rights-based acts, and Common Minimum Programmes.
Bahujan Resurgence & Regional Assertion	Rise of the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), OBC political parties, and the federalization of national governance.	Explaining Kanshi Ram's mobilization (BAMCEF, DS-4, BSP), the rise of regional caste parties, and the end of central unilateralism.
Democratic Upsurges & New Consensus	Yogendra Yadav's Three Democratic Upsurges, dominant coalitions, and the emerging national political consensus.	Analyzing the three upsurges (franchise, Mandal assertion, aspirational delivery) and the four pillars of contemporary political consensus.

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EXAM TIP

High-Scoring Insight & Key Cognitive Traps for CUET UG:

- **Mandal Commission Dates & Quotas:** Appointed in **1978** by the Morarji Desai Janata government; submitted report in **December 1980**; implemented on **7 August 1990** by Prime Minister V.P. Singh; recommended **27% reservation** for OBCs (who formed 52% of the population).
- **Indra Sawhney Benchmark (1992):** The 9-judge Supreme Court bench upheld the 27% quota, but imposed a strict **50% ceiling** on total reservations and mandated the exclusion of the **"creamy layer"**.
- **Unique Coalition Alignments:** In 1989, V.P. Singh's National Front was supported from the outside by both the **BJP** and the **Left Front** (ideological opposites). In 1996, the United Front was supported from the outside by the **Congress**.

- **First Non-Congress 5-Year Term:** The **NDA government (1999–2004)** under Atal Bihari Vajpayee was the first non-Congress coalition to complete a full five-year term in post-independence history.

1. The Historical Transition of the 1990s: Five Crucial Developments

The year 1989 marks the decisive end of the single-party "Congress System" at the Centre and the beginning of a quarter-century era of multi-party coalition governance in India. Political scientists view the decade of the 1990s as a foundational turning point shaped by five interconnected developments:

1. **The Collapse of Congress Dominance (1989):** In the Ninth General Elections of November 1989, the Congress party's parliamentary tally plunged from 415 seats (won in 1984) to 197 seats. Although Congress remained the single largest party, it lacked an absolute majority and declined to stake a claim, inaugurating the era of coalition politics where no single party secured an absolute majority in the Lok Sabha until 2014.
2. **The Mandal Issue & Rise of OBC Politics:** The implementation of the Second Backward Classes Commission recommendations in August 1990 by Prime Minister V.P. Singh sparked nationwide student protests and permanently altered the social composition of political representation, ushering in the political empowerment of the Other Backward Classes (OBCs).
3. **Structural Economic Reforms (1991):** Confronting an acute balance-of-payments crisis where foreign exchange reserves dropped to barely two weeks of imports, Prime Minister P.V. Narasimha Rao and Finance Minister Dr. Manmohan Singh initiated historic structural adjustment reforms—ushering in Liberalisation, Privatisation, and Globalisation (LPG)—dismantling the Nehruvian "License-Permit-Quota Raj".
4. **The Ayodhya Dispute and Rise of Hindutva:** The unlocking of the gates of the disputed Babri structure in 1986, L.K. Advani's Somnath-to-Ayodhya **Rath Yatra** in 1990, and the demolition of the 16th-century Babri Masjid on 6 December 1992 precipitated communal violence and elevated cultural nationalism (Hindutva) into a dominant axis of national electoral competition.
5. **The Assassination of Rajiv Gandhi (May 1991):** During an election rally in Sriperumbudur, Tamil Nadu, former Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi was assassinated by a suicide bomber of the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE). This shifted national sympathy towards Congress, enabling P.V. Narasimha Rao to lead a minority government that governed for a full five years (1991–1996).

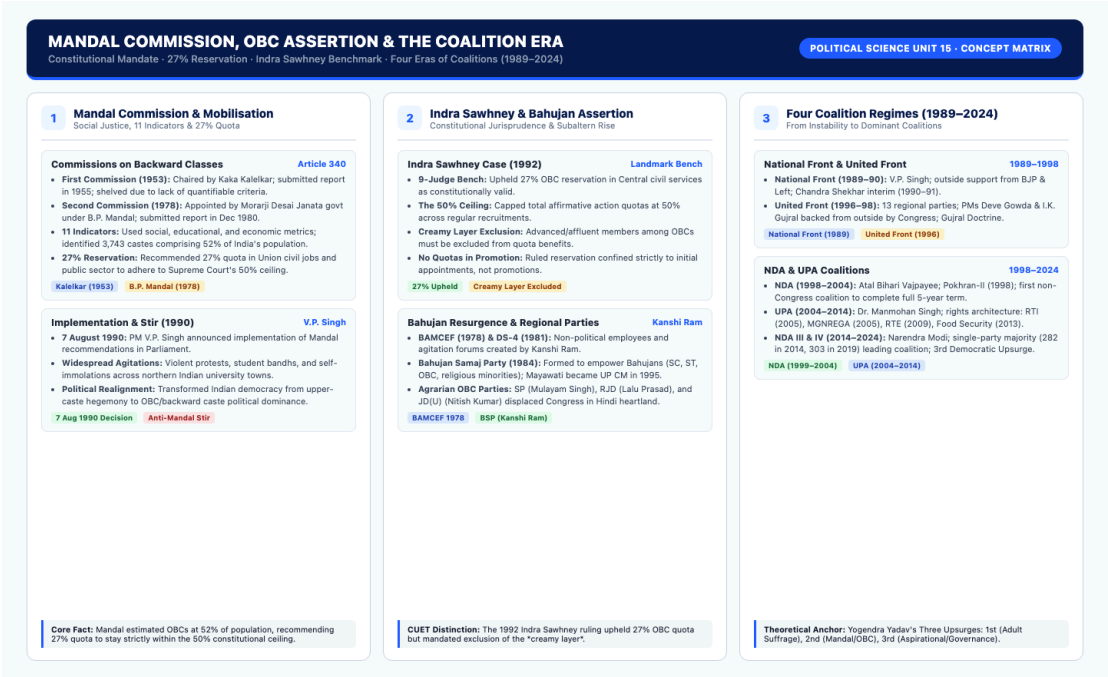


Figure 1: Figure 1 — Mandal Commission, OBC Assertion & Coalition Era: Constitutional mandate, 27% reservation, the Indra Sawhney ruling, and the four coalition regimes from 1989 to 2024.

2. The Rise of Janata Dal and the National Front (1989–1990)

The political alternative to Congress was forged through the consolidation of centrist and agrarian opposition forces:

Formation of the Janata Dal

- **The Bofors Catalyst:** In 1987, Vishwanath Pratap Singh (V.P. Singh), Union Finance and Defense Minister in Rajiv Gandhi's cabinet, resigned following public allegations of kickbacks and corruption in the procurement of Swedish Bofors 155mm howitzer guns.
- **The Merger:** V.P. Singh founded the **Jan Morcha**. In October 1988, the Jan Morcha merged with the Janata Party, Lok Dal (Chaudhary Devi Lal and Ajit Singh factions), and Congress (S) to establish the **Janata Dal**.
- **The National Front:** The Janata Dal formed an alliance with prominent regional parties—including the DMK in Tamil Nadu, Telugu Desam Party (TDP) in Andhra Pradesh, and Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) in Assam—under the banner of the **National Front**.

The National Front Government (1989–1990)

- **The Unique Ideological Geometry:** Following the 1989 elections, V.P. Singh was elected leader and sworn in as Prime Minister. The National Front commanded only 143 seats and was sustained in power by a unprecedented external floor alliance: supported from the outside simultaneously by the right-wing **Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP, 85 seats)** and the **Left Front (45 seats)**. Both supporting blocs declined to join the cabinet, sitting on opposite sides of the treasury benches.
- **Internal Factional Discord:** Deputy Prime Minister Chaudhary Devi Lal, representing the powerful agrarian peasant lobby of northern India, frequently clashed with V.P. Singh. When Devi Lal was sacked from the Union Cabinet on 1 August 1990, he announced a massive peasant rally in New Delhi. To outmaneuver Devi Lal's rural mobilization and consolidate an unassailable backward-class vote base, V.P. Singh made the sudden announcement in Parliament

on **7 August 1990** that his government would implement the recommendations of the Mandal Commission.

- **The Fall of the Government (November 1990):** In response to the Mandal mobilization, BJP President L.K. Advani embarked on a nationwide **Rath Yatra** to mobilize Hindu public opinion behind the Ram Janmabhoomi movement. When Advani was arrested in Samastipur on the orders of Bihar Chief Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav in October 1990, the BJP formally withdrew its outside support. V.P. Singh lost a vote of confidence on 7 November 1990 by 142 to 346 votes, ending his 11-month tenure.

Chandra Shekhar's Minority Government (1990–1991)

Following V.P. Singh's resignation, **Chandra Shekhar** broke away from the Janata Dal with 64 MPs to establish the **Samajwadi Janata Party (Rashtriya)**. Chandra Shekhar assumed office as Prime Minister with outside floor support provided by Rajiv Gandhi's Congress (197 MPs). However, the fragile arrangement collapsed within four months when Congress accused the Haryana government of deploying plainclothes constables to spy outside Rajiv Gandhi's residence, prompting Chandra Shekhar to resign in March 1991.

3. The Mandal Commission and Other Backward Classes (OBC)

Affirmative action in post-independence India was originally confined to the Scheduled Castes (SC) and Scheduled Tribes (ST). The constitutional struggle to extend reservations to the intermediate agrarian and artisan castes—collectively designated the **Other Backward Classes (OBCs)**—transformed the social hierarchy of Indian democracy.

Constitutional Origins and Prior Commissions

- **Article 340 Mandate:** Article 340 of the Constitution empowers the President to appoint a commission to investigate the conditions of socially and educationally backward classes and recommend remedial measures.
- **The First Backward Classes Commission (1953):** Chaired by veteran Gandhian **Kaka Kalelkar**, the First Commission submitted its report in 1955 identifying 2,399 backward castes. However, the report was shelved by the Central government due to internal dissensions (including Kalelkar's own ambiguous dissenting note) and the lack of quantifiable, objective criteria.
- **Southern Precedents & The Karpoori Thakur Formula:** While northern India lagged, southern states had instituted backward-class reservations decades earlier. In Bihar, socialist Chief Minister **Karpoori Thakur** introduced a pioneering layered reservation formula in 1978 allocating quotas separately for Other Backward Castes (12%), Extremely Backward Castes (8%), women (3%), and economically backward upper castes (3%), serving as a direct precursor to national OBC affirmative action.

The Second Backward Classes Commission (Mandal Commission)

- **Appointment (1978):** In December 1978, the Morarji Desai-led Janata Party government appointed the Second Backward Classes Commission under the chairmanship of **Bindeshwari Prasad Mandal (B.P. Mandal)**, former Chief Minister of Bihar.
- **Scientific Methodology & 11 Indicators:** The Mandal Commission devised 11 indicators grouped into three broad dimensions:
  1. **Social Indicators (4):** Castes considered socially backward by others; dependent on manual labor; high female labor participation; early marriage rates.

2. **Educational Indicators (3):** Low school attendance; higher dropout rates; lower proportion of matriculates.
3. **Economic Indicators (4):** Family assets below state average; living in kachha dwellings; consumption debt; lack of access to drinking water.

- **Key Findings:** The Commission identified **3,743 castes** as backward, estimating that the OBCs constituted approximately **52% of India's total population** (excluding SCs and STs).
- **The 27% Quota Recommendation:** While the OBC population stood at 52%, the Commission recommended a **27% reservation** in Central government civil posts, public sector undertakings, and higher educational institutions, ensuring that total reservations (22.5% for SC/ST + 27% for OBC = 49.5%) stayed strictly within the 50% ceiling established by Supreme Court jurisprudence in the **M.R. Balaji (1963)** case.
- **Submission (1980):** The Mandal Commission submitted its landmark report in December 1980, but it remained unaddressed during the Indira Gandhi and Rajiv Gandhi administrations until V.P. Singh announced its implementation on 7 August 1990.

Implementation and the Indra Sawhney Judgment (1992)

V.P. Singh's decision ignited furious upper-caste student protests, violent demonstrations, and tragic self-immolations across northern India. The constitutional validity of the 27% quota was challenged before the Supreme Court.

- **The 9-Judge Constitutional Bench:** In the historic **Indra Sawhney v. Union of India (1992)** ruling (popularly known as the Mandal Case), the Supreme Court upheld the validity of the 27% OBC reservation by a 6:3 majority.
- **Core Judicial Directives:**
  1. **Validity of Caste:** Caste can be a valid criterion for determining social backwardness under Article 16(4).
  2. **The 50% Rule:** Total reservations in regular recruitments must not exceed **50%**, except under extraordinary regional circumstances.
  3. **The "Creamy Layer" Exclusion:** Advanced, socially and economically affluent individuals among the OBCs (e.g., children of constitutional dignitaries, Class I civil servants, large landowners, or high-income earners) must be excluded from affirmative action benefits.
  4. **No Quotas in Promotions:** Article 16(4) permits reservation only at the stage of initial entry into service, not in promotional posts. (Parliament later amended the Constitution via Articles 16(4A) and 16(4B) to protect SC/ST promotions).
- **Subsequent Educational Extensions:** In 2006, the UPA government enacted the Central Educational Institutions (Reservation in Admission) Act, extending the 27% OBC quota to central universities, IITs, and IIMs, which was upheld by the Supreme Court in **Ashoka Kumar Thakur v. Union of India (2008)**. In 2017, the Union appointed the **Justice G. Rohini Commission** under Article 340 to examine the sub-categorization of OBCs.

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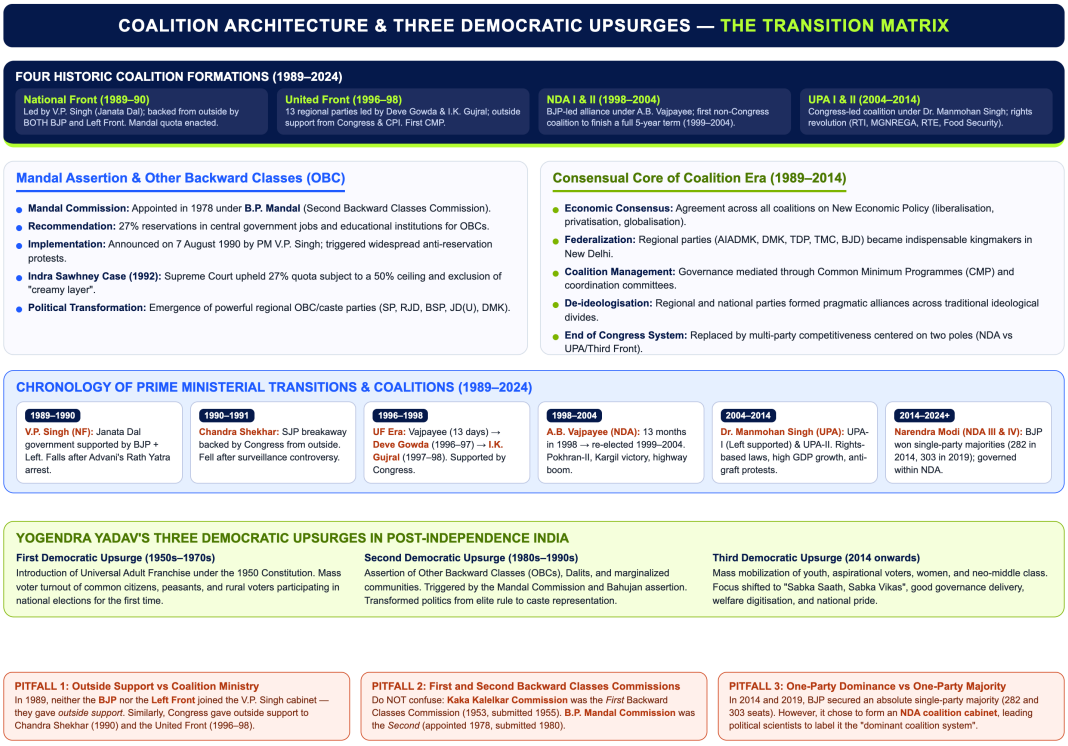


Figure 2: Figure 2 — Coalition Architecture & Transition Matrix: The four historic coalition regimes, Mandal jurisprudence, Prime Ministerial transitions (1989–2024), and Yogendra Yadav's upsurges.

4. Bahujan Resurgence and the Rise of Caste-Based Regional Parties

The implementation of Mandal and the political mobilization of marginalized castes revolutionized state-level party competition:

Kanshi Ram and the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP)

- **BAMCEF (1978):** In 1978, Dalit social reformer **Kanshi Ram** organized government employees from backward and minority communities into the **Backward and Minority Communities Employees Federation (BAMCEF)**, building an autonomous network of educated subaltern professionals.
- **DS-4 (1981):** In 1981, Kanshi Ram established the **Dalit Shoshit Samaj Sangharsh Samiti (DS-4)** to conduct direct mass agitational campaigns against caste discrimination.
- **Formation of BSP (1984):** In April 1984, Kanshi Ram launched the **Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP)**, aiming to unite the **Bahujan Samaj**—comprising Scheduled Castes, Scheduled Tribes, Other Backward Classes, and religious minorities (who together formed 85% of the population)—to wrest political power from the upper-caste minority.
- **Mayawati's Rise:** Under Kanshi Ram's mentorship, **Mayawati** emerged as a towering Dalit leader, becoming the Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh in June 1995 (heading a coalition with the Samajwadi Party and BJP support), the first Dalit woman to head a state government in India.

Agrarian OBC Regional Formations

Mandal mobilization catalyzed powerful regional parties dominated by agrarian middle castes:

- **Samajwadi Party (SP):** Founded by **Mulayam Singh Yadav** in 1992 in Uttar Pradesh, building a formidable coalition of intermediate agrarian castes (Yadavas) and Muslim minorities.

- **Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD):** Founded by **Lalu Prasad Yadav** in Bihar in 1997, commanding immense mass loyalty through the "MY" (Muslim-Yadav) social coalition and unyielding secularist politics.
- **Janata Dal (United) [JD(U)]:** Led by **Nitish Kumar** and George Fernandes, mobilizing Extremely Backward Classes (EBCs) and non-Yadav peasant communities in Bihar.

5. United Front Governments (1996–1998)

The 11th General Election of May 1996 produced a fractured mandate. The BJP emerged as the single largest party with 161 seats:

- **Vajpayee's 13-Day Government (May 1996):** President Shankar Dayal Sharma invited Atal Bihari Vajpayee to form the government. Unable to secure alliance partners due to the BJP's political untouchability over the Babri demolition, Vajpayee delivered an emotional televised farewell address in the Lok Sabha and resigned after **13 days** without facing a formal vote of confidence.
- **The United Front Coalition:** A coalition of 13 regional, socialist, and secular parties—including the Janata Dal, Samajwadi Party, DMK, TDP, AGP, and the Left Front—formed the **United Front (UF)**. When veteran Marxist Chief Minister Jyoti Basu was barred by the CPI(M) Politburo from accepting the Prime Ministership (which Basu later termed a **"historic blunder"**), Karnataka Chief Minister **H.D. Deve Gowda** was chosen as the compromise Prime Minister.
- **Outside Support by Congress:** The United Front commanded only 180 seats and survived solely on the external floor support of the Congress party (140 seats) and the CPI (which joined the cabinet).
- **The Gujral Administration (1997–1998):** In March 1997, Congress President Sitaram Kesri withdrew support from Deve Gowda. The United Front reconstituted itself under seasoned diplomat **Inder Kumar Gujral**. Gujral formulated the famous **Gujral Doctrine**, which posited that in its relations with smaller South Asian neighbors (Bangladesh, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Bhutan, Maldives), India—as the largest regional power—must extend unilateral concessions without seeking reciprocal favors. The Gujral government collapsed in November 1997 when Congress demanded the expulsion of DMK ministers following the Jain Commission's interim report on the assassination of Rajiv Gandhi.

6. The National Democratic Alliance (NDA: 1998–2004)

The 12th General Elections of 1998 saw the BJP shed its political isolation by stitching together a vast pre-poll and post-poll confederation of regional parties named the **National Democratic Alliance (NDA)**:

- **The 13-Month Government (1998–1999):** Atal Bihari Vajpayee took oath as Prime Minister in March 1998. The government conducted the historic **Pokhran-II** nuclear tests (**Operation Shakti**) on 11 and 13 May 1998, establishing India as a declared nuclear-weapon state. In April 1999, the AIADMK under J. Jayalalithaa withdrew its 18 MPs, and the Vajpayee government fell by a solitary vote (**269 to 270**) on the floor of the Lok Sabha.
- **Diplomacy and Conflict (1999–2002):** Vajpayee traveled to Pakistan on the inaugural Delhi-Lahore bus in February 1999, signing the historic Lahore Declaration. However, Pakistani forces infiltrated Kargil months later, prompting the Kargil War (Operation Vijay, May–July 1999) where Indian armed forces evicted all intruders. Following the 13 December 2001 Parliament

terrorist attack, India launched Operation Parakram and enacted the Prevention of Terrorism Act (POTA) in 2002.

- **The Full Five-Year Term (1999–2004):** In the October 1999 elections, the NDA swept to power with 303 seats. Vajpayee headed a 24-party coalition that governed until May 2004, becoming the **first non-Congress government in Indian history to complete a full five-year term**.
- **Major Policy Achievements:** National Highway Development Project (NHDP: Golden Quadrilateral and North-South/East-West Corridors), telecom deregulation under the New Telecom Policy (1999), the launch of **Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan**, and targeted disinvestment of public sector enterprises.

7. The United Progressive Alliance (UPA: 2004–2014)

Defying exit polls and the NDA's "India Shining" campaign, the May 2004 general elections returned the Congress as the single largest party with 145 seats:

- **The Creation of UPA:** Congress forged a post-poll coalition named the **United Progressive Alliance (UPA)**. In an emotional meeting of the Congress Parliamentary Party, Congress President Sonia Gandhi renounced the office of Prime Minister, nominating eminent economist and former Finance Minister **Dr. Manmohan Singh**, who was sworn in as Prime Minister.
- **UPA-I (2004–2009): Rights-Based Legislative Revolution:** Supported from the outside by the Left Front (61 MPs), UPA-I adopted a National Common Minimum Programme (NCMP) and enacted transformative welfare legislation:
  1. **Right to Information Act (RTI, 2005):** Empowered citizens to inspect government records, revolutionising transparency.
  2. **MGNREGA (2005):** Guaranteed 100 days of statutory wage employment per year to every rural household.
  3. **Forest Rights Act (2006):** Restored traditional land and forest rights to Scheduled Tribes and traditional forest dwellers.
- **The 2008 Nuclear Trust Vote:** When the Left Front withdrew support over the Indo-US Civil Nuclear Agreement in July 2008, the government survived a tense parliamentary confidence vote with support from the Samajwadi Party.
- **UPA-II (2009–2014):** In 2009, UPA was re-elected with an expanded tally of 262 seats (Congress winning 206 seats alone). It enacted the **Right to Education Act (RTE, 2009)** and the **National Food Security Act (NFSA, 2013)**, but was severely weakened by administrative paralysis and high-profile anti-corruption agitations (India Against Corruption led by Anna Hazare).

8. NDA III & IV: The Dominant Coalition Era (2014–2024)

The 16th General Election of May 2014 shattered the 25-year-old precedent of fractured mandates:

- **The 2014 Mandate:** The BJP under Narendra Modi secured **282 seats** on its own (commanding an absolute majority in the 543-member Lok Sabha), while the NDA secured **336 seats**. This was the first time since 1984 that any single party won a standalone majority.
- **The 2019 Mandate:** In May 2019, the BJP expanded its standalone majority to **303 seats** (NDA winning 353 seats).
- **Conceptualizing the "Dominant Coalition":** Political scientists, most notably Suhas Palshikar, characterized this phase as the **"Second Dominant Party System"** or the **"BJP-System"**. Unlike the fragile coalitions of 1989–2014 where the lead party was held hostage by

regional allies, NDA III and IV functioned as a "dominant coalition" where the principal party commanded an independent parliamentary majority while preserving the multi-party coalition format for wider federal legitimacy.

9. Yogendra Yadav's Three Democratic Upsurges

Eminent political scientist Yogendra Yadav formulated an influential conceptual model tracing the deepening of Indian democracy through three distinct "Democratic Upsurges":

Upsurge Phase	Time Period	Social Epicenter & Mobilization	Democratic Transformation
First Upsurge	1950s–1970s	Introduction of universal adult franchise; mobilization of peasant castes.	Shift of political participation from the westernized urban elite to rural agrarian communities; rise of state leaders like Kamaraj and Charan Singh.
Second Upsurge	1980s–1990s	Mandal mobilization; political assertion of OBCs and Dalits; Bahujan mobilization.	Displacement of upper-caste hegemony; rise of identity-based regional parties (SP, RJD, BSP, JD(U)); deepening of social representation.
Third Upsurge	2014 onwards	Aspirational youth, neo-middle class, women voters, and urban subalterns.	Electoral shift toward direct delivery of basic amenities (toilets, housing, digital welfare, gas connections) and national leadership.

10. The Emergent Political Consensus

Despite fierce partisan competition, the quarter-century of coalition governance forged an enduring, cross-party consensus around four cardinal principles:

1. **Consensus on Economic Policies:** Unbroken continuity in structural economic reforms, foreign investment, and infrastructure modernization across United Front, NDA, and UPA administrations.
2. **Acceptance of OBC Political Claims:** Universal political consensus regarding the legitimacy of reservations, welfare schemes, and legislative representation for the Other Backward Classes.
3. **Federalization of Power:** Irreversible recognition that central policy must accommodate state-level regional aspirations and autonomous state leadership.
4. **Pragmatic Governance over Dogmatic Ideology:** Transformation from rigid ideological confrontation to governance mediated through Common Minimum Programmes, cooperative federalism, and targeted welfare delivery.

Comparative Framework of National Coalitions (1989–2024)

Coalition Regime	Prime Ministers	External Support	Defining Hallmarks & Fall/Outcome
National Front (1989–90)	V.P. Singh	BJP & Left Front	Mandal Commission implementation; fell when BJP withdrew support after Advani's arrest.
SJP Minority (1990–91)	Chandra Shekhar	Congress (Rajiv)	Minority government of 64 MPs; collapsed when Congress withdrew support over surveillance.
United Front (1996–98)	Deve Gowda, I.K. Gujral	Congress & CPI	13 regional parties; Gujral Doctrine; collapsed after Jain Commission report dispute.
NDA (1998–2004)	Atal Bihari Vajpayee	AIADMK, TDP, Trinamool	Pokhran-II; Kargil War; first non-Congress coalition to complete full 5-year term.
UPA (2004–2014)	Dr. Manmohan Singh	Left Front (2004–08), SP	Rights-based legislation (RTI, MGNREGA, RTE); Indo-US Nuclear Agreement; 10-year rule.
NDA III & IV (2014–24)	Narendra Modi	None (Standalone majority)	Single-party majorities (282 & 303 seats); dominant coalition; direct benefit transfers.

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Chapter Synthesis & Cognitive Mindmap



Figure 3: Figure 3 — Democratic Upsurge and Coalition Politics Mindmap: Complete structural map of the 1989 transition, Mandal assertion, four coalition regimes, Yogendra Yadav's upsurges, and the new political consensus.

HIGH-YIELD MEMORY HOOKS & HISTORIOGRAPHICAL POINTERS

- **End of Congress System: 1989 General Election**; Congress tally reduced to **197 seats**; multi-party coalition era inaugurated.
- **National Front (1989–90): V.P. Singh** as PM; supported from outside by both **BJP** and the **Left Front** simultaneously.
- **Mandal Commission:** Appointed in **1978** (Janata govt); chaired by **B.P. Mandal**; recommended **27% quota** for OBCs (52% population); implemented **7 Aug 1990**.
- **Indra Sawhney Benchmark (1992):** 9-judge bench upheld 27% quota; imposed **50% ceiling**; excluded **"creamy layer"**; barred promotion quotas.
- **Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP):** Founded in **1984** by **Kanshi Ram**; preceded by BAMCEF (1978) and DS-4 (1981); **Mayawati** became first Dalit woman CM in 1995.
- **United Front (1996–98): H.D. Deve Gowda** & **I.K. Gujral** as PMs; supported from outside by Congress; **Gujral Doctrine** of non-reciprocal goodwill.
- **NDA Full Term (1999–2004): Atal Bihari Vajpayee**; first non-Congress coalition to complete full 5-year term; Pokhran-II (1998) & Kargil War (1999).
- **UPA Rights-Based Era (2004–2014): Dr. Manmohan Singh**; **RTI Act (2005)**, **MGNREGA (2005)**, **RTE Act (2009)**, **NFSA (2013)**.
- **Dominant Coalition Era (2014 onwards): Narendra Modi**; BJP won **282 seats** in 2014 and **303 seats** in 2019 (first single-party majorities in 30 years).
- **Yogendra Yadav's 3 Upsurges:** 1st (Adult Franchise 1950s), 2nd (Mandal/OBC 1980s–90s), 3rd (Aspirational Welfare 2014+).

MASTER STRATEGY CHEATSHEET — DEMOCRATIC UPSURGE & COALITIONS

▸**The 1990s Turning Point:** 1989 Congress collapse → Mandal mobilisation → 1991 LPG reforms → Ayodhya dispute → Rajiv Gandhi assassination. ▸**Mandal Jurisprudence & OBC Resurgence:**

- Article 340 → 1st Commission (1953, Kaka Kalelkar) → 2nd Commission (1978, B.P. Mandal, 11 indicators).
- 27% OBC reservation implemented **7 August 1990** by V.P. Singh.
- **Indra Sawhney (1992):** 27% upheld → 50% quota ceiling → Creamy layer exclusion → No promotion quotas.

▸**Subaltern Assertiveness:** Kanshi Ram creates BAMCEF (1978), DS-4 (1981), BSP (1984) → Rise of SP (Mulayam), RJD (Lalu), JD(U) (Nitish). ▸**Four Historic Coalition Regimes (1989–2024):**

- **National Front (1989–90):** V.P. Singh; supported outside by BJP & Left Front. Chandra Shekhar (1990–91) backed by Congress.
- **United Front (1996–98):** Deve Gowda & Gujral; supported outside by Congress; Gujral Doctrine.
- **NDA (1998–2004):** Atal Bihari Vajpayee; Pokhran-II, Kargil; first non-Congress full 5-year term.
- **UPA (2004–2014):** Dr. Manmohan Singh; rights-based era: RTI (2005), MGNREGA (2005), RTE (2009), Food Security (2013).
- **NDA III & IV (2014–24):** Narendra Modi; single-party majority leading dominant coalition (282 in 2014, 303 in 2019).

▸**Yadav's 3 Upsurges:** 1st (Franchise/Peasantry), 2nd (Mandal/OBCs), 3rd (Aspirational/Governance).

THE SEVEN FATAL CUET TRAPS

1. **First vs Second Backward Classes Commission: Kaka Kalelkar** chaired the 1st (1953); **B.P. Mandal** chaired the 2nd (1978). Never confuse them!
2. **Mandal Quota vs Population:** Mandal identified OBCs as **52%** of population, but recommended a **27% quota** to stay within the 50% legal limit.
3. **Creamy Layer Mandate:** The Supreme Court in **Indra Sawhney (1992)** did NOT strike down OBC quotas; it **upheld** them with creamy layer exclusion.
4. **1989 Outside Supporters:** V.P. Singh was supported by **both the BJP and the Left Front**, neither of which joined the government.
5. **First Non-Congress 5-Year Term:** The **NDA government (1999–2004)** completed 5 years; the 1977 Janata Party government collapsed after 2.5 years.
6. **Gujral Doctrine Essence:** Based on **non-reciprocity** (unilateral goodwill to smaller neighbours), NOT on strict mutual quid-pro-quo.
7. **Single-Party Majority Year:** 2014 was the first single-party majority (BJP 282) **since 1984**, ending 30 years of hung parliaments.

Practice Questions (Exam Pattern)

Fifteen authentic CUET UG examination-standard multiple-choice questions testing conceptual, chronological, institutional, and factual mastery. Marking scheme: +5 for correct answer, −1 for incorrect attempt.

Part 1: The 1989 Transition, National Front & Mandal Commission

Q1. Which year marked the formal end of the single-party 'Congress System' at the Centre, inaugurating a quarter-century of coalition governments?

(A) 1977 (B) 1984
(C) 1989 (D) 1996

Sol. Q1. The 1989 general election ended single-party Congress dominance at the Centre; although Congress won 197 seats, it chose to sit in opposition, ushering in multi-party coalition rule. **Answer: (C)**

Q2. The National Front government led by Prime Minister V.P. Singh in 1989 was supported from the outside by which unique ideological pairing?

(A) Congress and CPI (B) The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the Left Front
(C) AIADMK and DMK (D) Janata Party and Swatantra Party

Sol. Q2. The National Front government under V.P. Singh was supported from the outside simultaneously by both the right-wing BJP and the Left Front, sitting on opposite sides of the house. **Answer: (B)**

Q3. Under Article 340 of the Indian Constitution, who chaired the Second Backward Classes Commission appointed by the Morarji Desai government in 1978?

(A) Bindeshwari Prasad Mandal (B.P. Mandal) (B) Kaka Kalelkar
(C) Jagjivan Ram (D) Chaudhary Charan Singh

Sol. Q3. The Second Backward Classes Commission was appointed in December 1978 under the chairmanship of B.P. Mandal. Kaka Kalelkar chaired the First Commission in 1953. **Answer: (A)**

Q4. In which landmark verdict did a nine-judge Constitution bench of the Supreme Court uphold the 27% OBC reservation while capping total reservations at 50% and excluding the 'creamy layer'?

(A) Kesavananda Bharati Case (1973) (B) Minerva Mills Case (1980)
(C) Indra Sawhney v. Union of India (1992) (D) S.R. Bommai Case (1994)

Sol. Q4. In Indra Sawhney v. Union of India (1992), a 9-judge bench validated the 27% OBC quota, imposed a 50% ceiling on total reservations, and mandated the exclusion of the creamy layer. **Answer: (C)**

Q5. The 'Gujral Doctrine', formulating five principles of non-reciprocal unilateral goodwill towards India's South Asian neighbours, was propounded by Prime Minister:

(A) I.K. Gujral (B) P.V. Narasimha Rao
(C) H.D. Deve Gowda (D) Atal Bihari Vajpayee

Sol. Q5. Inder Kumar Gujral authored the Gujral Doctrine, advocating unilateral, non-reciprocal goodwill and concessions by India towards smaller South Asian neighbors. **Answer: (A)**

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Part 2: Coalition Tenures, Rights Acts & Bahujan Resurgence

Q6. Which was the first non-Congress coalition government in post-independence India to complete a full five-year term in office?

(A) The Janata Party Government (1977–1982)
(B) The National Democratic Alliance (NDA) led by Atal Bihari Vajpayee from 1999 to 2004
(C) The United Front Government (1996–2001)
(D) The United Progressive Alliance (2004–2009)

Sol. Q6. The NDA government under Atal Bihari Vajpayee, elected in October 1999 following the Kargil War, governed until May 2004, completing the first non-Congress full five-year term. **Answer: (B)**

Q7. According to political scientist Yogendra Yadav's analytical framework, the 'Second Democratic Upsurge' in Indian politics was primarily marked by:

(A) The introduction of universal adult suffrage in the 1950s
(B) The youth-driven aspirational voting and digitisation post-2014
(C) The adoption of Liberalisation, Privatisation, and Globalisation in 1991
(D) The electoral mobilisation and political empowerment of Other Backward Classes (OBCs) and Dalits

Sol. Q7. Yogendra Yadav identified the Second Democratic Upsurge (1980s–1990s) as the social justice and Mandal mobilisation of Other Backward Classes and Dalits entering state power. **Answer: (D)**

Q8. Which landmark rights-based act guaranteeing 100 days of guaranteed wage employment to rural households was enacted by the UPA-I government in 2005?

(A) Right to Information Act
(B) Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA)
(C) Right to Education Act
(D) National Food Security Act

Sol. Q8. The Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) was enacted in 2005 under UPA-I, providing a statutory guarantee of 100 days of rural wage employment. **Answer: (B)**

Q9. The minority government led by Prime Minister Chandra Shekhar in 1990–1991 came to power with the outside floor support of which party?

(A) Bharatiya Janata Party
(B) Left Front
(C) Indian National Congress led by Rajiv Gandhi
(D) Telugu Desam Party

Sol. Q9. Following the collapse of the V.P. Singh ministry in November 1990, Chandra Shekhar formed the Samajwadi Janata Party, governing with outside support from Rajiv Gandhi's Congress. **Answer: (C)**

Q10. In the 2014 general election, how many seats did the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) secure on its own, winning the first single-party parliamentary majority in 30 years?

(A) 282 seats
(B) 272 seats
(C) 303 seats
(D) 336 seats

Sol. Q10. In the 2014 Lok Sabha elections, the BJP won 282 seats on its own (while the NDA won 336 seats), crossing the 272-seat majority mark for the first single-party majority since 1984. **Answer: (A)**

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Part 3: Subaltern Mobilisation, Electoral Crises & Political Consensus

Q11. The Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), established in 1984 to represent the interests of Bahujans (SC, ST, OBC, and religious minorities), was founded under the leadership of:

(A) Dr. B.R. Ambedkar
(B) Jagjivan Ram
(C) Mayawati
(D) Kanshi Ram

Sol. Q11. Kanshi Ram founded the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) in 1984 to mobilize the Bahujan Samaj (comprising 85% of society) to capture state power and dismantle caste hierarchy. **Answer: (D)**

Q12. BAMCEF (Backward and Minority Communities Employees Federation), which served as the organizational precursor to the Dalit political resurgence, was established in 1978 by:

(A) Kanshi Ram
(B) Ram Vilas Paswan
(C) Chaudhary Charan Singh
(D) Karpoori Thakur

Sol. Q12. Kanshi Ram organized educated government servants from marginalized communities into BAMCEF in 1978, establishing an autonomous institutional vanguard for subaltern politics. **Answer: (A)**

Q13. In the 1996 General Elections, Atal Bihari Vajpayee was sworn in as Prime Minister for the first time, but resigned after how many days due to lack of majority support?

(A) 10 days
(B) 13 days
(C) 30 days
(D) 60 days

Sol. Q13. Atal Bihari Vajpayee was sworn in as Prime Minister in May 1996 as leader of the single largest party, but resigned after 13 days unable to secure coalition partners. **Answer: (B)**

Q14. The First Backward Classes Commission in post-independence India was appointed in 1953 under the chairmanship of:

(A) B.P. Mandal
(B) Justice J.C. Shah
(C) Kaka Kalelkar
(D) Justice G.T. Nanavati

Sol. Q14. The First Backward Classes Commission was appointed under Article 340 in 1953 under the chairmanship of Kaka Kalelkar, submitting its report in 1955. **Answer: (C)**

Q15. In the coalition era post-1989, what became the standard institutional mechanism for managing ideological differences and guiding policy decisions among coalition partners?

(A) Issuing presidential ordinances
(B) Enforcing a single party constitution on all partners
(C) Amending the Tenth Schedule anti-defection law
(D) The drafting and adoption of a Common Minimum Programme (CMP)

Sol. Q15. Coalitions such as the United Front, NDA, and UPA routinely navigated disparate ideological platforms by drafting and adhering to a formal Common Minimum Programme (CMP). **Answer: (D)**

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